CHAPTER 4

The critical literature review

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

After completing Chapter 4 you should be able to:

1. Discuss the functions of a literature review.
2. Write a literature review on any given topic, documenting the references in the prescribed manner.
3. Discuss the ethical issues of documenting the literature review.

INTRODUCTION

In Chapter 3, we explained that a first review of the academic literature will help you to narrow down the broad problem and to develop a clear and specific problem statement. But mere definition of the problem does not solve it. How, then, does one proceed further? One answer is by going through the entire process as shown in the research process model in Figure 4.1. This figure illustrates that the next step, after you have developed a research proposal, is the critical literature review. This step is designated step 4 and it is indicated by the shaded portion in the figure.

The aim of this chapter is to introduce you to the process of carrying out a **literature review**. The chapter begins with a definition of the critical literature review, followed by a discussion of its functions. Then it will explain that a critical literature review is a step-by-step process that involves the identification of published and unpublished work from secondary data sources on the topic of interest, the evaluation of this work in relation to the problem, and the documentation of this work. Finally, this chapter will discuss two pitfalls you have to be aware of when you document the literature review: misrepresenting others and plagiarism.

To be able to generate viable alternatives for effective decision making you have to become an expert on your topic. A second review of the literature, or **critical literature review**, is therefore essential in most research projects. A literature review is "the selection of available documents (both published and unpublished) on the topic, which contain information, ideas, data and evidence written from a particular standpoint to fulfill certain aims or express certain views on the nature of the topic and how it is to be investigated, and the effective evaluation of these documents in relation to the research being proposed" (Hart, 1998 , p. 13).

In general, a literature review ensures that: